

Answer Key: The Platform and the Public Square Worksheet

Teacher's copy — do not distribute to students

Part	Task Type	Qs	Marks
A	Yes / No / Not Given	1–7	7
B	Note Completion (1 word)	8–16	9
C	Short Answer	17–22	6
D	Vocabulary Matching	23–30	8
E	Gap-Fill	31–39	12
F	Extended Writing	40	4
TOTAL			46 marks

PART A — YES / NO / NOT GIVEN [7 marks]

These test the writer's CLAIMS — not just facts. Accept YES / NO / NOT GIVEN or Y / N / NG. No partial marks.

- NO** Part One explicitly states platforms are advertising businesses motivated by engagement — not education.
- YES** MIT Finding box: 'false news stories spread significantly faster, further and more broadly than true ones.'
- NO** Part Four: 'it would be a serious oversimplification to attribute this trend entirely to social media.'
- NO** Part Six: the writer argues platforms cannot claim neutrality and that their content decisions are 'editorial decisions with profound consequences.'
- YES** Part Six: 'The European Union has moved furthest with its Digital Services Act, which imposes significant obligations on large platforms.'
- YES** Part Five: 'The paradox of the authentic influencer is that their authenticity is itself a product.'
- NOT GIVEN** The writer calls for change but does not predict whether platforms will reform voluntarily — this is not stated.

PART B — NOTE COMPLETION [9 marks]

One word only — exact word from the article. Do not accept synonyms unless noted.

8.	engagement	Part One: 'their revenue depends on keeping users on the platform ... longer engagement.'
9.	experience	Part One: 'human experience and behaviour are harvested as raw data.' Accept: behaviour.
10.	reinforces	Part Two: 'content that reflects and reinforces their existing preferences and beliefs.'
11.	confirmation	Part Two: 'confirmation bias ... is systematically amplified.'
12.	intention	Part Three: 'shared without the intention to deceive.'
13.	said	Part Three: 'make public figures appear to say things they never said.'
14.	radical	Part Four: 'guide users towards progressively more radical content.'
15.	comparison	Part Five: 'social comparison: the curated highlight reels ... compare unfavourably.'
16.	editorial	Part Six: 'they are editorial decisions with profound consequences.'

PART C — SHORT ANSWER QUESTIONS [6 marks]

Award 1 mark for any answer clearly conveying the key idea. Do not penalise grammar errors if meaning is clear.

17.	Because outrage, fear, and moral indignation generate more comments, shares, and interactions — the algorithm rewards emotional engagement, not accuracy.	Key idea: algorithm rewards engagement → outrage content is more engaging → structural advantage for extreme/emotional content.
18.	Misinformation is false information shared without intent to deceive (the sharer believes it's true); disinformation is deliberately false, created and spread with the explicit intention to deceive.	Key idea: intent is the distinction — misinformation is accidental, disinformation is deliberate.
19.	Not primarily to support a specific candidate, but to deepen polarisation, inflame social divisions, and undermine confidence in democratic institutions.	Key idea: the goal was destabilisation / polarisation — NOT to elect a specific person.
20.	Because their decisions about content moderation, algorithm design, and what speech is permitted are inherently editorial decisions that determine what billions of people can see and say.	Key idea: their decisions are editorial in nature — remove, promote, downrank = editorial control.

21. **That their apparent openness and vulnerability — which appears genuine — is actually a carefully managed performance, subject to the same commercial calculations as any other media product.**

Key idea: the 'authenticity' is itself a curated, commercially motivated construction.

22. **That aggressive moderation risks censoring legitimate speech, while light moderation allows harmful content to flourish — there is no neutral middle position, and someone must make the value judgement.**

Key idea: no neutral option — either remove too much or too little — someone must decide, raising questions of who has that authority.

ANSWER KEY — PARTS A, B, C · SOCIAL MEDIA WORKSHEET

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PART D — VOCABULARY MATCHING [8 marks]

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| 23. | e — filter bubble | <i>A personalised environment showing only content aligned with existing beliefs.</i> |
| 24. | d — surveillance capitalism | <i>Harvesting personal data to predict and influence behaviour commercially.</i> |
| 25. | b — echo chamber | <i>An environment reinforcing one set of views while excluding alternatives.</i> |
| 26. | a — disinformation | <i>Deliberately false information spread with the intention to deceive.</i> |
| 27. | g — deepfake | <i>A synthetic AI-generated video making someone appear to say something they did not.</i> |
| 28. | h — astroturfing | <i>Creating fake grassroots campaigns to simulate popular support.</i> |
| 29. | f — radicalisation | <i>Gradual exposure to increasingly extreme content via recommendation algorithms.</i> |
| 30. | c — polarisation | <i>Societies splitting into opposing groups with increasing mutual hostility.</i> |

PART E — GAP-FILL [12 marks]

Award 1 mark per blank. Most sentences require 2–3 answers — mark each blank independently.

31. **algorithm / engagement** 2 blanks — 1 mark each.

32.	filter bubble / echo chamber / confirmation bias	3 blanks — 1 mark each.
33.	amplification / bot	2 blanks — 1 mark each. Accept: engagement for first blank.
34.	misinformation / disinformation / propaganda	3 blanks — 1 mark each. Accept in any order.
35.	deepfake / astroturfing	2 blanks — 1 mark each. Accept in either order.
36.	polarisation / democratic discourse / epistemic	3 blanks — 1 mark each.
37.	geopolitical	1 blank.
38.	tribalism / amplification	2 blanks — 1 mark each.
39.	content moderation / democratic	2 blanks — 1 mark each. Accept: epistemic for second blank.

PART F — EXTENDED WRITING [4 marks]

Mark holistically. Award marks for: (1) a clear position stated, (2) at least one argument from the article used as support, (3) at least one counterargument acknowledged, (4) appropriate Level B vocabulary used (at least 2 highlighted words from the article). Do not penalise grammar errors unless they prevent comprehension.

4 marks	Clear position; 2+ article arguments used; counterargument acknowledged; 3+ key terms used correctly; 80–100 words.
3 marks	Clear position; 1–2 arguments from article; some key terms used; approximately correct length.
2 marks	Position stated but underdeveloped; limited use of article content or key vocabulary.
1 mark	Some attempt at a response; minimal engagement with the article's argument.
0 marks	No clear position; no engagement with the article; off-topic or blank.

MARKING SUMMARY

A (Y/N/NG): 7 marks · B (Note completion): 9 marks · C (Short answer): 6 marks · D (Matching): 8 marks · E (Gap-fill): 12 marks · F (Writing): 4 marks · TOTAL: 46 marks